WYOMING

The Equality State

ILLUSTRATION PLACEHOLDER

Illustrated Wyoming landscape inside the state shape

Wyoming has always been a land that feeds you on its own terms.

The Shoshone and Bannock peoples had known the cutthroat trout long before anyone else thought to name it. In the cold, fast-moving waters of the Green River, the Snake, and the Yellowstone—rivers that carved themselves through high desert and pine forest with equal indifference—the native cutthroat thrived. It was reliable, abundant, and deeply woven into the subsistence life of the people who understood this landscape best. They caught it by hand, by weir, and by spear, and they ate it beside fires that had been burning in these valleys for thousands of years.

When the mountain men arrived in the early 1800s, they found both the rivers and the fish waiting for them. Figures like John Colter and Jim Bridger pushed deep into Wyoming's interior, trapping beaver along the same waterways the cutthroat called home. The annual Rocky Mountain Rendezvous, held along the Green River near present-day Pinedale beginning in 1825, gathered trappers, traders, and Native peoples in a sprawling summer gathering that was equal parts commerce and survival. Along those riverbanks, cutthroat trout pulled from the cold current and cooked over open flame became as much a part of the mountain man's table as hardtack and dried venison—simple, sustaining, and honest.

The cattle drives of the 1860s and 1870s brought a different kind of hunger to Wyoming. Cowboys pushing vast herds north along the Chisholm and Goodnight-Loving trails into Wyoming's open ranges were men who ate what the land provided between towns. When a drive crossed a river—the North Platte, the Powder, the Sweetwater—a cowboy with a line in the water and a cutthroat on the hook had something worth stopping for. Cast iron over a trail fire, a little rendered fat, salt from the chuck wagon, and a fresh-caught trout was as close to a celebration as trail life allowed. The "cowboy cut" became the rancher's way of preparing the whole fish simply and completely, wasting nothing, honoring everything.

Wyoming's territorial cooks and, later, the ranch wives who fed crews through brutal winters and blazing summers, refined what the mountain men and cowboys had cooked by necessity into something with genuine regional pride. The cutthroat trout was eventually designated Wyoming's state fish in 1969, a formal recognition of what the people of this state had known for generations.

When you make this dish, you are reaching back through all of that—the Shoshone fisherman, the frost-bearded trapper, the trail-worn cowboy—and pulling something elemental forward into your own kitchen. The preparation is straightforward, the ingredients unfussy, and the result is the kind of meal that makes you understand why people fell so completely in love with this wild, uncompromising place. It's perfect for outdoor grilling, cast-iron searing, or oven roasting. Fire it up, and taste what Wyoming is made of.

COWBOY CUTTHROAT TROUT

From cold mountain streams to cast-iron legend, let the wild spirit of the West guide your hand and feed your soul.

Yield: 2–4 servings

INGREDIENTS

TROUT

- 2 whole Wyoming cutthroat trout, cleaned and gutted (or 4 fillets)
- 2 Tbsp olive oil or melted butter

SMOKY-SPICY RUB

- 1 tsp cumin
- 1 tsp smoked paprika
- 1 tsp chili powder
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- 1 tsp brown sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- ¼ tsp black pepper
- Pinch of cayenne for extra heat (optional)
- Lemon wedges, to serve
- Fresh herbs (parsley, thyme, or dill), for garnish

Serving Tip: Pair with roasted vegetables, wild rice, or a fresh corn salad for a hearty Wyoming-style meal. The rub's subtle sweetness balances the smokiness, making it a crowd-pleasing dish for campers, backyard grillers, or cozy home dinners.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Preheat cooking surface*: Prepare a grill over medium heat or preheat oven to 400°F (204°C). Lightly oil the grates or a baking sheet.
2. *Prepare the rub*: In a small bowl, combine cumin, smoked paprika, chili powder, garlic powder, brown sugar, salt, and pepper and cayenne, if using. Mix well.
3. *Season the trout*: Pat the trout dry with paper towels. Brush the fish with olive oil or melted butter, inside and out. Sprinkle the smoky-spicy rub generously over the fish, pressing lightly to adhere.
4. *Grill or oven-bake the trout*: To grill, place the trout over medium heat and cook 4–6 minutes per side for fillets, or 6–8 minutes per side for a whole fish, until the flesh is opaque and flakes easily with a fork. To oven-bake, place the trout on a lined baking sheet and bake 15–20 minutes for fillets or 20–25 minutes for a whole fish, until cooked through and reaches an internal temperature of 145°F (63°C).
5. *Serve*: Transfer to a platter, garnish with fresh herbs, and squeeze lemon over the top. Serve immediately.

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Cowboy Cutthroat Trout — finished dish illustration

Food only (finished dish, ingredients or preparation) — no people